

Give Every Piece a Job

Choose destinations that serve a target, a stable square, or an open line.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Put a rook on a file with an entry square

P. 3

02 Check whether the outpost can be chased

P. 6

03 Find a real route for the bishop

P. 9

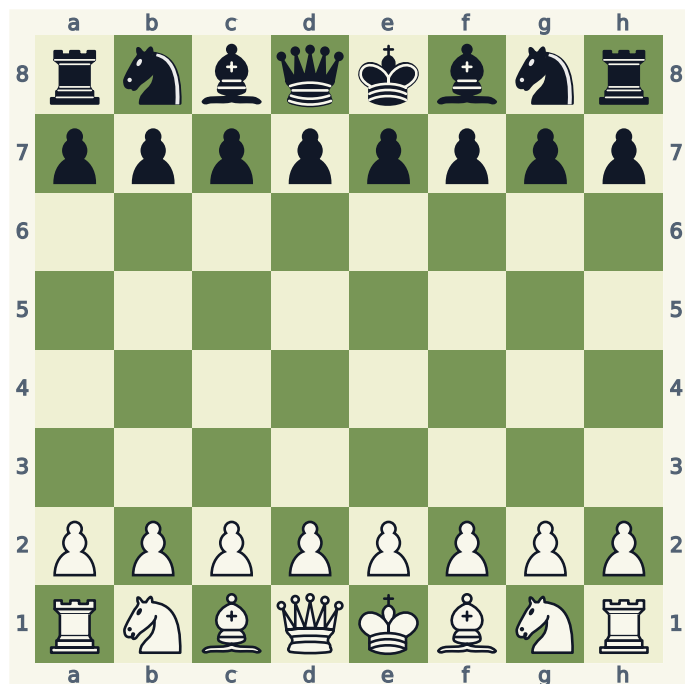
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

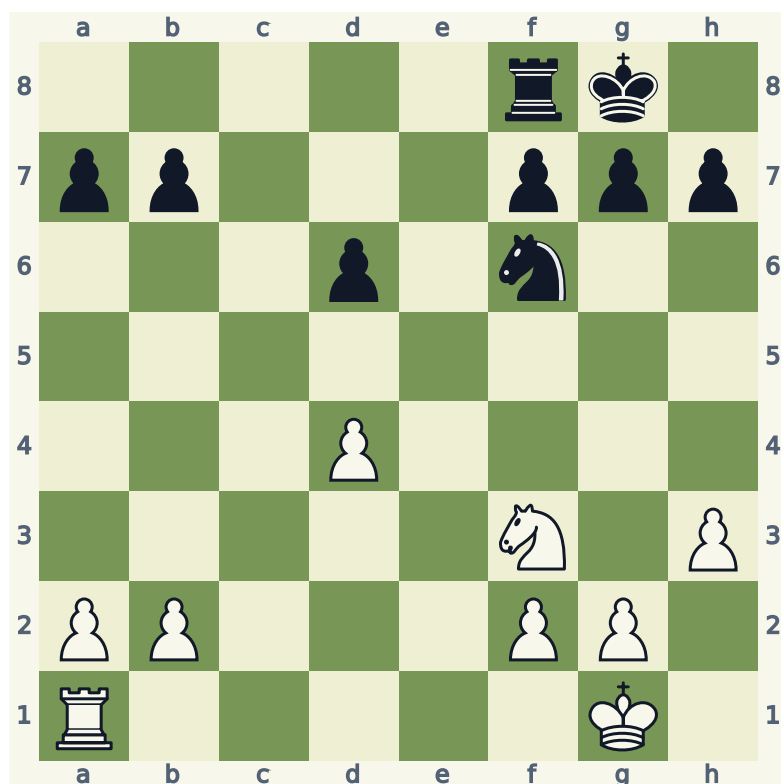
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Put a rook on a file with an entry square

A rook belongs on a useful file, not automatically on whichever file is empty. Look for a target, an entry square, and a safe route to that square.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The c-file contains no pawn of either color.
2. The seventh rank contains targets on a7 and b7.
3. The c7 entry square is not protected by a black pawn, knight or king.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Rc1 Re8 2. Rc7

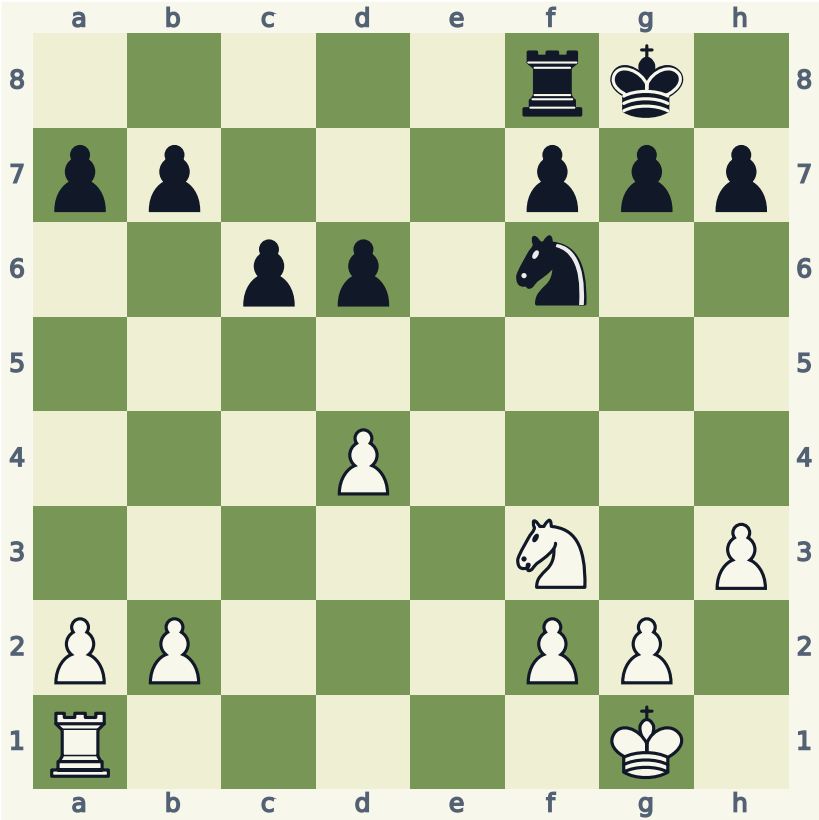
Rc1 places the rook on the open c-file. If Black continues ...Re8, White can invade with Rc7 and attack along the seventh rank. The sequence illustrates a route; ...Re8 is not forced, and Black could instead contest the c-file.

Before invading, inspect the destination. A rook that reaches the seventh rank but can be captured has accomplished nothing. Here c7 is safe, and the rook can attack pawns from the side. That concrete target explains the file choice.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. How does the pawn on c6 change the file?
2. After Rc1 ...Re8, can White simply play Rc7?
3. What useful job can the rook still do on c1?

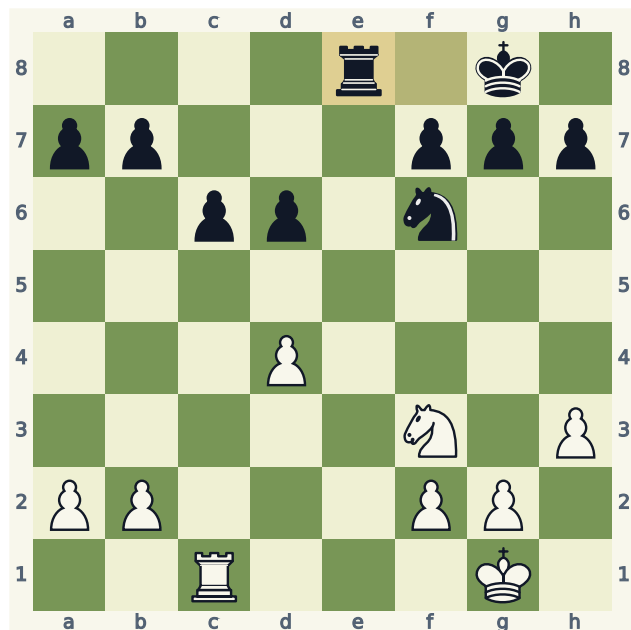
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pp3ppp/2pp1n2/8/3P4/5N1P/PP3PP1/R5K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Rc1 Re8

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The c-file is now semi-open for White: White has no pawn on it, but Black has the c6-pawn. The pawn blocks the rook's route toward the seventh rank.

2. No. A rook cannot jump over c6 to reach c7. Rxc6 is a different move, and the black b7-pawn can recapture on c6, so the pawn is not free.

3. The rook can pressure c6 and make Black account for that target. White would need additional pressure or a structural change before winning it. Rc1 is a planning candidate, not a claim that this material-down position is equal.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

An open file is not a permanent entitlement. The opponent can challenge it with a rook, protect the entry square, or create a more urgent threat elsewhere.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

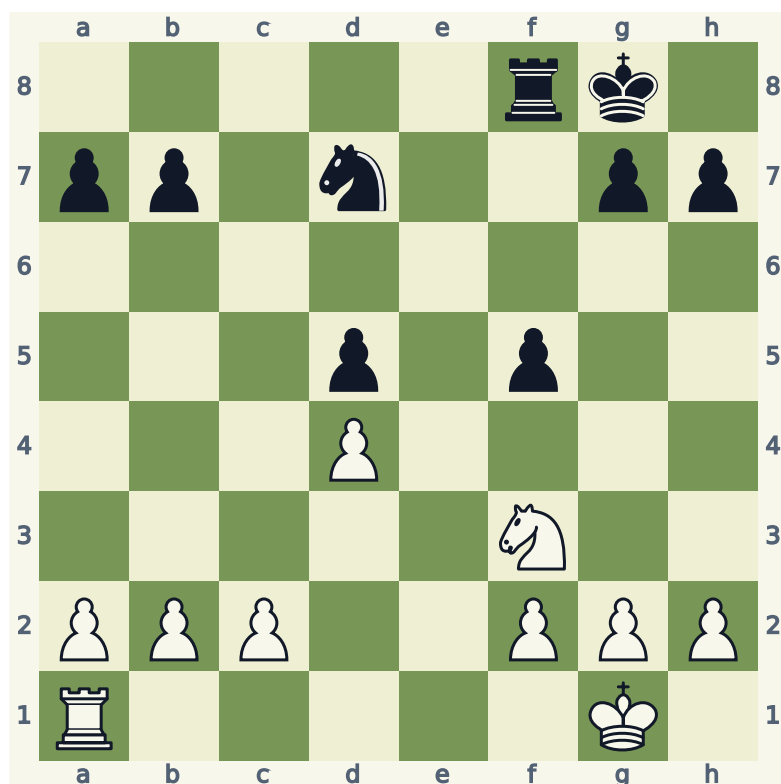
For each rook in one of your games, name a file, an entry square, and the piece that controls the entry. If you cannot name the entry, look for a target first.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Check whether the outpost can be chased

A stable knight square is supported and difficult for enemy pawns to attack. Check pawn direction and future pawn moves before calling a square an outpost.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's d4-pawn protects e5.
2. Black's pawns on d5 and f5 have already passed the squares from which they could attack e5.
3. Black can still contest the knight with a piece; pawn immunity does not mean complete immunity.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Ne5 Nf6 2. Rc1

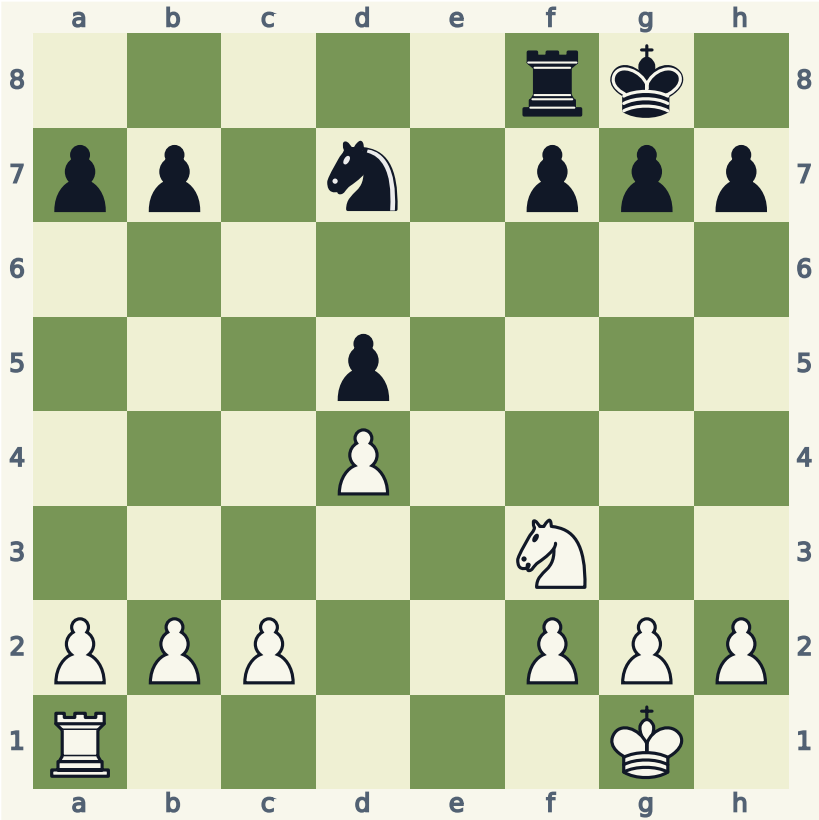
Ne5 places the knight on a supported central square. Black's d5-pawn attacks c4 and e4; the f5-pawn attacks e4 and g4. Neither can move backward to challenge e5 with a pawn.

After the illustrative ...Nf6, Rc1 improves the remaining piece. Black also has ...Nxe5 from d7, when dxe5 recaptures. That exchange changes the pawn structure. A good square improves your choices; it does not prevent your opponent from exchanging pieces.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. What future pawn move can Black use against a knight on e5?
2. Test Ne5 and give a retreat after that challenge.
3. Does this mean Ne5 is illegal or always a blunder?

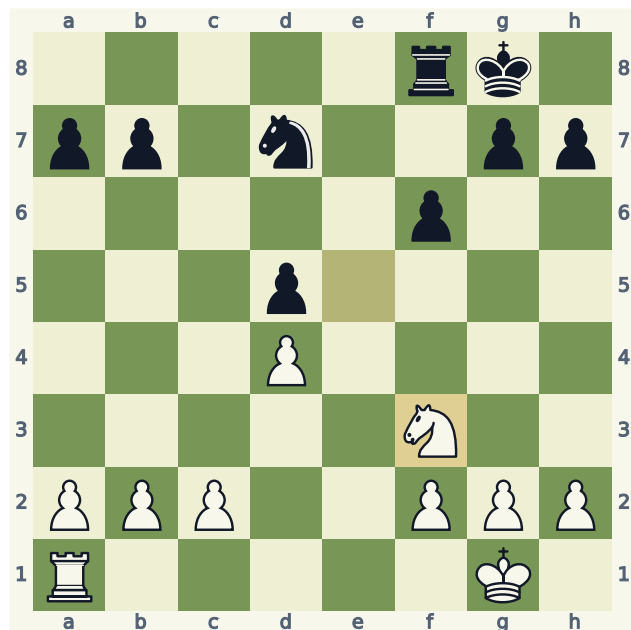
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pp1n1ppp/8/3p4/3P4/5N2/PPP2PPP/R5K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Ne5 f6 2. Nf3

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The f-pawn is still on f7, so ...f6 is available. A black pawn on f6 attacks e5. This future possibility changes the square's stability.

2. Ne5 f6 Nf3 shows the knight being driven away. The route back is legal, but White has spent time going to a square that Black can challenge. This is a comparison line, not a recommendation to repeat the maneuver.

3. No. A temporary knight move can gain time or provoke a weakening pawn move in a richer position. Here the exercise asks whether e5 is a permanent pawn-proof outpost; it is not. Check the whole position before choosing the move.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Do not define an outpost by a knight's attractive appearance alone. Check whether an adjacent enemy pawn can advance to a square that attacks it, and whether exchanging the knight helps you.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

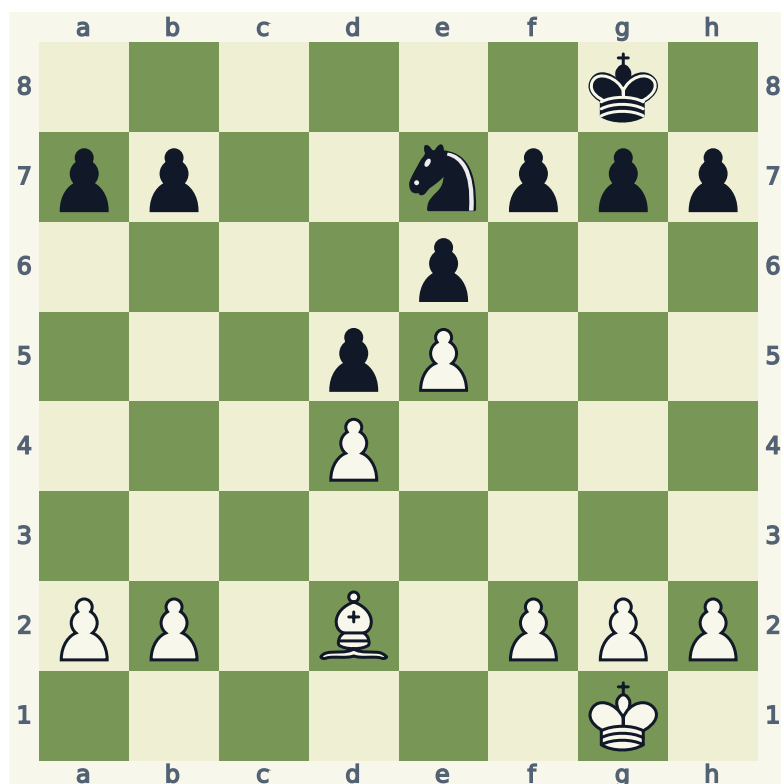
Find a candidate outpost in a game. Draw the enemy pawns' possible future attacks, then identify which friendly pawn or piece would recapture an exchange there.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Find a real route for the bishop

Improve a restricted bishop by finding a real route outside its pawn chain. A useful destination is only useful if the bishop can legally reach it.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's pawns on d4 and e5 occupy dark squares and limit the dark-squared bishop's central diagonals.
2. From d2, the diagonal through c3 and b4 is clear.
3. A bishop on d6 would attack e7 and c7 and help control Black's position.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Bb4 Nc6 2. Bd6

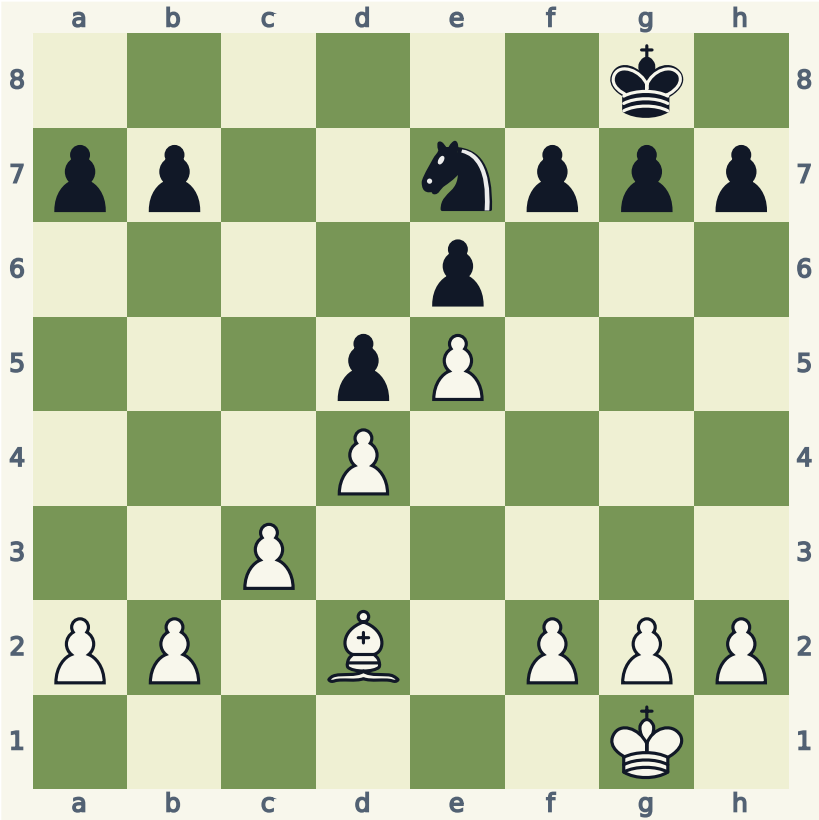
Bb4 takes the bishop outside the pawn chain. After the sample ...Nc6, Bd6 completes the route. This improves the bishop's scope without needing to move the central pawns first.

Black is allowed to react differently, so the route is a plan rather than a forced sequence. Test each step for captures and tactical threats. The purpose of a maneuver is to increase useful control, not merely to move a piece several times.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Which square on the Model A route is now occupied?
- 2. Is Bb4 legal from d2 in this position?
- 3. Suggest another development square and describe its current limitation.

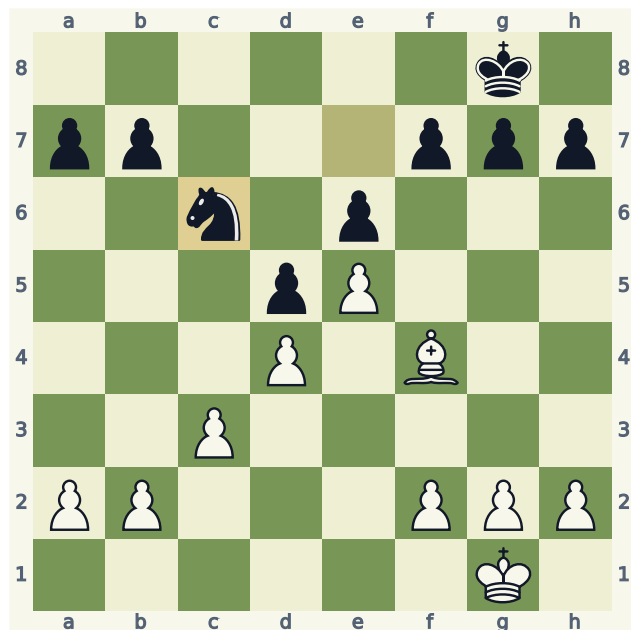
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 6k1/pp2nppp/4p3/3pP3/3P4/2P5/PP1B1PPP/6K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Bf4 Nc6

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. White has added a pawn on c3. It stands directly on the bishop's route d2-c3-b4.

2. No. The bishop cannot jump over its own pawn. The presence of an attractive square on b4 does not create a legal route to it.

3. Bf4 is legal through e3. It places the bishop outside d2 and controls squares such as g5, although its own e5-pawn still blocks the diagonal toward d6. It is a modest improvement, not a claim that the bishop is suddenly unrestricted.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

A bishop blocked by its own pawns is not worthless. It may defend those pawns. Improve it only when leaving its defensive job does not lose something more important.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Choose your least active bishop from a recent game. Write one destination and every intervening square. Then identify the defensive job you would leave behind.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. What turns an open file into a useful route?
2. Why is e5 more stable against pawns on d5 and f5 than against a pawn on f7?
3. What should you check before starting a bishop maneuver?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. A safe entry square and a concrete target, together with time to reach them.
2. The advanced pawns cannot move backward to attack e5; the f7-pawn can advance to f6 and attack it.
3. The complete route, safety at each stop, the destination's useful targets, and any defense the bishop would abandon.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.